

■ Chapter 10 ■

Structure and Agency

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Every time we construct, however tentatively, a notion of social, political or economic causality we appeal, whether explicitly or (more likely) implicitly, to ideas about structure and agency. The way our explanations are formulated reflects a deeper set of understandings about the (relative) autonomy of actors or agents in the settings in which they find themselves. What model of the nature of political actors are we creating in our explanations? Are these actors the unwitting products of their context, helpless individuals with minimal control over their destiny, floundering around in a maelstrom of turbulent currents; or are they knowledgeable and intentional subjects with complete control over the settings which frame their actions? Are the effects we wish to explain the products of actors displaying their agency, making unconstrained choices; or are these effects the products of the unfolding logic of a structure (or set of structures) over which agents (individual or collective) have no control?

We can ask these questions of every political situation we are interested in explaining and we will no doubt come to different answers depending upon the specific nature of each action setting. None the less, our answers to these questions are highly significant. Clearly, it makes a difference whether we explain the electoral success of the Conservatives in the British General Election of 1992 as a consequence of John Major's charisma, personality and leadership (an agency-orientated account, however unlikely); or as nothing to do with John Major or even the Conservative Party at all, but rather as a product of the influence of a biased media in constructing perceptions of the incompetence and unreliability of the Labour Party (a more structural account, perhaps equally inadequate).

In this chapter I hope to demonstrate that structure and agency logically entail one another – a social or political structure only exists by virtue of the constraints on, or opportunities for, agency that it effects. Thus, it makes no sense to conceive of structure without at least hypothetically positing some notion of agency which might be effected (constrained or enabled). If, for instance, we are interested in the structures imposed by the

surface and atmosphere of Mars, we necessarily do so by considering the potential constraints placed upon human agents hypothetically deposited on to this alien landscape – Is there an atmosphere? If so, is it breathable? Can we walk on the surface? How difficult will it be to extract valuable minerals from the planet's rocks? and so on.

Furthermore, I wish to argue that within every social or political context (however mundane) we witness a variety of accomplished, complex and sophisticated displays of agency. As we shall see, such displays are generally the product of intentional action informed by some 'knowledge' (however intuitive and however misinformed) of the structures that define the setting for that action. Such knowledgeability is a condition of effective action (action likely to achieve intended outcomes – whether explicitly acknowledged or not). When orientated to a specific task, intention or motivation yields *strategy*. At its most straightforward, strategy involves the selection of objectives and the search for the most appropriate means to achieve those objectives within a particular context at a particular moment in time. Here it is important to emphasise that appropriate strategies change with time. Agency, then, is the product of *strategy* and *intention*. The ability to formulate strategy (whether explicitly, or more probably, intuitively) is the condition of all action (this is summarised in Figure 10.1).

Figure 10.1 *Intention, strategy and action*

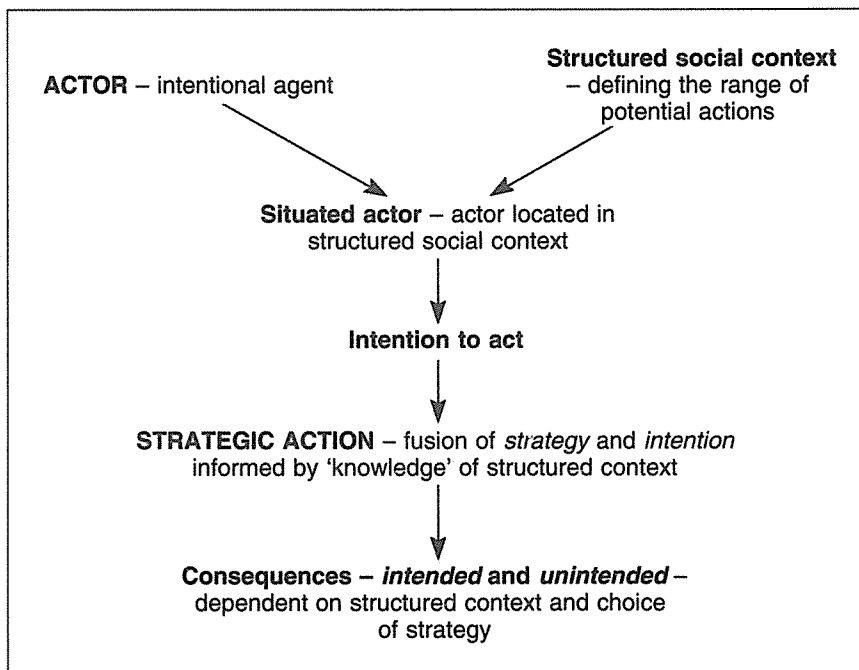


Figure 10.2 *Interrogating conceptions of structure and agency in political explanation*

- Who is the agent in our explanation?
- Is our agent individual or collective?
- If collective, how is this collectivity sedimented and/or mobilised?
- If there is no agent, how do the effects we describe appear?
- Have we contextualised our agent within the broader structural and strategic context?
- How relevant is this context in accounting for the consequences (both intended and unintended) of the actions that we have identified?
- Have we considered adequately the extent to which this relevant context constrains and/or enables our agent?

Conceptions of structure and agency are implicit in *every* explanation and attribution of causality to social and/or political actors. As a consequence, we can benefit greatly from seeking to render explicit the conceptions of structure and agency that we necessarily appeal to, and by asking ourselves a series of related questions, thereby interrogating the notions of causality we formulate (see Figure 10.2).

Furthermore, ideas of structure and agency are central to any notion of *power*. This would not come as any great surprise to students of French, since the verb *pouvoir* meaning 'to be able' also doubles as the noun *pouvoir*, meaning 'power'. Indeed, if we probe a little deeper in to the English language, a similar link may be found. Etymologically, 'power' is derived from the Old French verb *poeir* and ultimately the Latin *posse* meaning 'to be able'. Similarly, an 'agent', as defined in the *Penguin English Dictionary*, is 'one who acts, or *exerts power* to bring something about' (emphasis added) and in the *Oxford English Dictionary* as 'a person . . . that *exerts power* or *produces an effect*' (emphasis added). Hence, power is fundamentally bound up with the idea of the victory of the *agent* or *subject* over its other – *structure* or *object*. Power is a question of agency, of influencing or 'having an effect' upon the structures which set contexts and define the range of possibilities of others. This suggests the need for a *relational* conception of both structure and agency: one person's agency is another person's structure. Attributing agency is therefore attributing power (both causal and actual). The actions of ministers and governments produce the structures that constrain junior civil servants and state functionaries, the effects of whose actions similarly constrain the rest of us.

This lies at the heart of the fundamental distinction between the natural sciences on the one hand and the social sciences on the other. The difference lies in the fact that the social and political sciences must deal with active and intentional agents, however constrained. The natural

sciences, by contrast, are concerned with the elucidation of trans-historical structures and what might be termed *metastructures* – the structures and laws that govern the evolution of dynamic systems such as the geological plates which make up the earth's surface. Within the natural sciences the only approximation to the concept of agency in social science is 'that not yet accounted for' – that is, the effects of as yet unexplained structures. These differences are usefully summarised by Bhaskar (1979) and define the limits to the possibility of developing a social scientific *naturalism* (in which the methods of the natural sciences might be applied to social science):

1. Social structures, unlike natural structures, do not exist independently of the activities they govern;
2. Social structures do not exist independently of the agents' conceptions of what they are doing in their activity; and
3. Social structures may be only relatively enduring.

■ Positions in the structure–agency debate

Since notions of structure and agency are so thoroughly bound up with questions of power, causality and political explanation, the question of structure and agency lies at the heart of the philosophy of the social and political sciences and, as a consequence, has attracted a lot of close attention. The ways in which political scientists deal with such issues reflect their underlying philosophical assumptions about:

- (i) The nature of the social and political world and of 'social being' in particular. Such a theory or philosophy of social being is referred to as an ontology; and
- (ii) The nature of what constitutes an adequate and valid explanation of a political event, effect or process – a theory of knowledge or epistemology.

So different positions with respect to structure and agency reflect different epistemologies and ontologies. These epistemological and ontological concerns in turn influence the very process or methodology of political enquiry. We can usefully distinguish between different approaches on the basis of their answers to the following questions:

- To what extent are individuals' actions the product of socialisation and hence structures over which they have minimal control, to what extent are they the product of rational choice or intention on the part of autonomous subjects? (Ontological)

- To what extent is the autonomy of actors constrained by the structures these actors 'bear' – their positions within a patriarchal and racist society; their position with respect the relations of production, and so on – and the contexts in which they find themselves? (ontological)
- How should we seek to explain a particular political effect – as the consequence of the intentions and actions of the immediate actors involved, or in terms of the logic or structure of the broader relations of which these actors form a part? What constitutes an adequate explanation? (Epistemological)

If we do this a number of distinct positions emerge, among which the following have proved the most influential: (a) structuralism; (b) intentionalism; (c) structuration theory; and (d) critical realism.

Figure 10.3 *Positions in the structure–agency debate*

	<i>'Insider' account (agency-centred)</i>	<i>'Outsider' account (structure-centred)</i>
Simple view of structure–agency	Intentionalism	Structuralism
Dialectical view of structure–agency	Structuration theory	Critical realism – strategic-relational approach

□ *Structuralism*

Structuralism, and its alter ego, functionalism, are now little more than terms of abuse within social and political theory. Very few, if any, contemporary theorists would volunteer the label 'structuralist' to categorise their own work, and even fewer would wish to be described as functionalist. None the less, the structuralist position was at one time highly influential and still represents a crucial point of departure for many current approaches to the perpetual problem of structure and agency. Basically, a structuralist viewpoint privileges structure within the structure–agency relationship, seeking to account for observable social and political events, processes and outcomes in terms of the operation of *unobservable* social and political structures of which actors are merely bearers (*Träger*). Structuralist modes of thought are examples of what

Wendt (1991) terms 'outsider' accounts which operate at some distance from actual human agents, preferring instead to contextualise actors within the structures that are understood to constrain them and that generally lie outside their immediate perceptions. Structuralism operates with what might be labelled a 'simple' or monocausal view of the relationship between structure and agency in which structure is largely seen to *constrain* and even *determine* agency (see Figure 10.3). Within structuralist accounts, explanations are not sought in terms of the motivations, intentions, strategies and actions of agents, since these are seen as mere artefacts of ultimately determinant structures. Notions of causality must, instead, arise out of a consideration of the complex interplay or 'overdetermination' of structures and systems which have their own 'relative autonomy' (Althusser, 1969; Poulantzas, 1973).

Structuralism is associated closely with *determinism*, *functionalism* and all forms of *teleologism* (the view that social and political processes, particularly processes of change, can be accounted for in terms of an historical end-state to which they are believed to evolve inexorably). Thus, for instance, many versions of the Marxist philosophy of historical materialism are seen as forms of economic determinism in which all aspects of social and political life are explained in terms of the economic relations which underlie them, and in which the evolution of structures as diverse as the state and the family are seen to be driven by the incessant unfolding of economic relations towards an historical end point – Communism.

Within functionalist modes of thought, specific social and political outcomes are explained, not in terms of the motivations and intentions of the actors involved, but in terms of the consequences of their effects. Thus, from such a perspective, the emergence of more consensual forms of capitalism related to the extension of the franchise, the creation of the welfare state, and the more general expansion in the ideological apparatuses and resources wielded by the state might be accounted for in terms of the state's 'function' of securing the conditions for the continued accumulation of capital. The problem with such modes of explanation is that the *mechanisms* whereby these effects are secured are never elucidated. Thus functionalism often becomes in fact a surrogate for explanation, a form of pseudo-explanation. This has the effect of diverting attention from the full complexity of processes, such as the evolution of state structures, which in fact have to be accounted for in terms of the dialectical interplay of structure, strategy and struggle.

Structuralism has over the years been exposed to a number of devastating critiques:

1. It underestimates systematically, and at times ignores completely, the activity of individuals, explaining away their real autonomy and denying that they have an effect or make a difference.

2. Thus structuralism paints a picture of the social and political world in which we are all mere automata, passive dupes of structures beyond our comprehension and over which we can exert no influence. As a consequence, it is incapable of distinguishing between Fascist authoritarianism on the one hand and liberal democracy on the other – each is considered to be equally ‘bad’. Such an undifferentiated view of political systems is not of much practical use and certainly does not provide the basis for informing political intervention (which presumably makes no difference in any case).
3. Relatedly, the deterministic and teleological view of social and political development which structuralism supports is accused of encouraging fatalism and passivity (often against its own best intentions). For, if the course of human history is ultimately (pre)-determined and leading inexorably towards some end-point, then all we can do is sit back and wait for the inevitable unfolding of history’s inherent logic.
4. Finally, there is a fundamental contradiction within structuralist modes of explanation. Put simply, if structuralist thought is indeed correct, and we are all merely passive dupes of the structures we bear, could the structuralist position ever be expressed? How is it that structuralist scholars from their ivory towers could step outside the structures which inevitably constrain and construct the rest of us, in order to describe them? Structuralism thus appears to rely on an extremely patronising and condescending distinction between the ‘enlightened’ theorist and the masses, which is logically unsustainable.

☐ *Intentionalism*

Structuralism’s ‘other’ is intentionalism. If structuralism is an ‘outsider’ account, then intentionalism is an ‘insider’ account that focuses on social practices, human agency and the rich texture of social and political interaction. Intentionalism too works with a ‘simple’ or monocausal view of the relationship between structure and agency, conceiving of structures (where such a notion is appealed to) as the product of intentional action. The concepts of constraint and context are largely absent from such accounts, which tend to take issues of social and political interaction largely at face value, constructing explanations out of the direct intentions, motivations and self-understandings of the actors involved and using explanatory concepts which lay actors might themselves use to account for their actions.

Intentionalism is closely associated with the notions of *indeterminacy*, *contingency*, *voluntarism*, and, above all, *methodological individualism* (the view that in formulating social and political explanations we should start and finish with the individual). Thus intentionalists tend to reject

deterministic explanations which seek to account for specific events and outcomes in terms of theoretical abstractions that are imported by the theorist (like the capital-labour relation), in favour of explanations couched in terms of the directly observable events themselves. Thus links between specific contexts or settings of interaction tend not to be drawn, since explanations are sought which reflect the uniqueness and 'richness' of social and political interaction in a given setting. The focus is largely upon the *micro-practices* of social interaction as opposed to the *macro-embeddedness* of action within broader social and political structures. In contrast to notions of determinacy, intentionalist accounts tend to stress the contingent nature of social and political processes – that is, the idea that outcomes cannot be predicted in advance and are, by contrast, the product of specific intentional acts whose effects we might scrutinise but whose existence is largely the product of chance and intention neither of which is subject to social and political investigation.

In emphasising the contingent nature of social and political effects, intentionalists are often accused of *voluntarism* – the view that in order to understand political outcomes we must merely consider the motivation and intentions of actors as if there was some one-to-one correlation between the intent and the effect of action. If structuralist accounts tilt the stick too far towards the pole of structure, where everything can be accounted for without recourse to a notion of agency, then intentionalism is guilty of the converse, failing to consider the structural constraints on the realisation of actors' intentionality.

Whereas structuralism has now been relegated to a mere term of abuse, intentionalism lives on, most notably in the work of the rational choice theorists, public choice theorists, analytical Marxists, pluralists and journalists (Downs, 1957, 1967; Elster, 1979, 1982, 1983, 1989a, 1989b, 1993; McLean, 1987; Roemer, 1987; Przeworski, 1985; Sen, 1977; see also Dunleavy, 1991). These theorists focus on individuals as selfish and independent utility maximisers, as rational strategic calculators and as intentional actors (Dunleavy, 1991, pp. 2–7; Kontopoulos, 1993, pp. 89–90). The individualist emphasis of rational choice theory is reflected in Elster's recent description of his own work as 'political psychology' (Elster, 1993) and it has been widely and variously criticised. These critiques (see ch. 4) have stressed the 'illogical' nature of much human behaviour; the importance of the *unintended* consequences of action (whether rational or irrational); the partial and often misleading information individuals use to inform their strategic calculations; and the need for a *relational* conception of rationality – no 'pure' rational action exists outside of, and unaffected by, the situational context and social structures in which it is embedded – hence, an understanding of context is in fact a condition of any notion of rationality (Boudon, 1981; Dunleavy, 1991; Kontopoulos, 1993).